

rows of camphor trees on her way to school. She was going to school but sometimes it seemed as if she were headed toward an indefinite place, a direction that was not a direction, because those steps seemed to float on a happy cloud of dreams.

In harsh hot and rainy seasons that girl crossed a bridge and walked under camphor trees to arrive finally at her rendezvous location. But a rendezvous doesn't mean something is promised. Because in that surreal time a promise was an unbelievable fantasy. No surreal dream will ever come true: All are bound to disappear.

That girl who walked through those rows of camphor trees now lives in a faraway place and has a different life. Everything that remains is only a memory. All memories are worth remembering but at some point must be forgotten. That girl was Diễm of bygone days.

## APPENDIX F

### “PLAYING GAMES” [TRÒ CHƠI]

BY TRỊNH CÔNG SƠN

*I do not know where this article first appeared. To my knowledge it has not been reprinted in any journal or book, but it can be found online at the following website: <https://trinhcongsonblog.wordpress.com/2013/08/17/tro-choi/>.*

*The following translation is by Cao Thị Như Quỳnh.*

When you feel that the game of life has something disturbing about it, then look for a quiet place, close the doors and pretend that you have thrown yourself into a fit of dreamlike pain. Choose whatever pain you like but make sure it's painful—so excruciatingly painful that death has the opportunity to gaze at you and test your fate. And when you reach a point that seems the most hopeless, suddenly from distant meadows healthy breezes arrive, bringing with them a fragrance of green rice, mint, and wild flowers. These breezes revive you and bring to life again the spring seasons that lie asleep, forgotten in your veins. That is also a time of rebirth of small living things in the swamps and of the awakening of wise men on high mountains or in deep grottos.

In a month when you must visit five or seven seriously ill patients, attend ten funerals and twenty weddings (including in one case two or three in an hour), then that fiendish month is no longer fun. It is a hellish game. When a game becomes hellish there is no reason to play it anymore. It's better to withdraw and run away quickly.

Perhaps of all the games the game of friends causes the least grief. It can be either a lot of fun or only a little fun, but it doesn't cause heartrending

pain. But if you are unlucky and the game of friends suddenly leads to a heartrending situation, you should be polite and open your heart several more times and reflect on what happened. Don't let a misunderstanding lead to more misunderstanding. Don't let the traces of jealousy affect your trust in your friends.

There are houses that collapse because of unstable foundations. There are gardens that are scraggly because they lack fertilizer. Don't make things already very heavy even heavier because the added burden will only weigh down our minds even more. Know how to forget and how to leave behind things that cannot travel forward with us.

There are games that we never grow tired of. On the other hand, there are quite a few games that we lose interest in after playing them only a few times. Once you've begun the game of drinking alcohol or tea it's hard to withdraw. Drinking tea has become a *tao* [path, way, religion; Vn: đạo]. Almost everyone has heard of the tao of tea. It is one of the high class leisure games of old sages. The game of drinking alcohol is closer to real life. It is a friend, a lover. It is happiness and also sadness. It is words of comfort. It is a source of inspiration. It is sharing and returning a favor. To sum up, for people who know how to drink alcohol as an elegant game it is everything. Drink alcohol to love life and people more and to love even the ghost-like, firefly-like flickering of betrayal in love.

If you keep your promise with the fields of grain and grapes, the game of drinking alcohol never causes any calamities. I have passed through those fields and walked through the doors that lead to the home of very high oak barrels filled with an amber liquid, and in each of those fragrant drops a silent and mysterious life is developing each day, even each minute, continuing in the silent darkness a process that has been going on for hundreds of years. During those hundreds of years alcohol does not sleep: It is awake. Awake and transforming itself. Transforming itself into a body that is soft and supple, transparent, and fragrant.

When the game of drinking alcohol does not invite us anymore we sigh for a while and tell ourselves this does not mean we have been abandoned. This is only a brief separation and it won't be too long before drops of fragrant alcohol fill crystal glasses again during quiet and private parties or in animated and cozy gatherings with friends.

There are a thousand and one games but for me the dearest and most splendid games are love, life, and alcohol. Those are the games that have chosen me and I have accepted them—accepted them like the first and last

choice of a fate that is neither colorful nor gloomy. I circle around these games as I circle around compassion. These games sometimes liberate me, help me rise up from dark and hellish holes of decline; and sometimes they press me deeply into suffering.<sup>†</sup>

I don't applaud and promote any particular game because I want to preserve my integrity and compassion. Ever since I entered this life I have encountered love and alcohol. Now I am saying good-bye once more. Good-bye to those glasses of warm alcohol in the morning, noontime, afternoon and night. My life is now free of games. A white colorless life. Playing the game of life without color forces me to find myself, to search for a face that does not look like the one in the past.

<sup>†</sup> "Suffering" here is our translation of *trầm luân*, a word which means "suffering" or "misfortune." It evokes the Buddhist concept of *samsara*, the cycle of births and deaths, the cycle of existence.